

A living hell

Andersonville, or Camp Sumter, was all these camps writ large. Carved out of the pinewoods of southwestern Georgia in early 1864, it was a stockade built for 10,000 Union prisoners that soon held three times that number. It offered no shelter. The sweltering inmates stretched rags on sticks and burrowed into the ground to escape the relentless sun. Its one creek was both water source and camp sewer. Dysentery was rampant, medical attention nonexistent, and rations sparse. Nearly 13,000 men died there—30 percent of the prison's population. Andersonville became the most infamous of Civil War prison camps, but all of them shared, to an extent, its sins.

Over 400,000 men were at some point held as prisoners of war during the conflict, and more than 56,000 of them died in captivity. Ultimately the death rate for both North and South together was approximately 13 percent—more than twice the death rate on the battlefield.